# Amtrak Rail Pass

This summer, I plan to use the Amtrak Rail Pass to travel for 1 month. This blog will contain my plans for the journey, and my thoughts on each day's experiences.
The following map gives an overview of the approximate Amtrak routes across the U.S. Chicago is the center of the rail network.

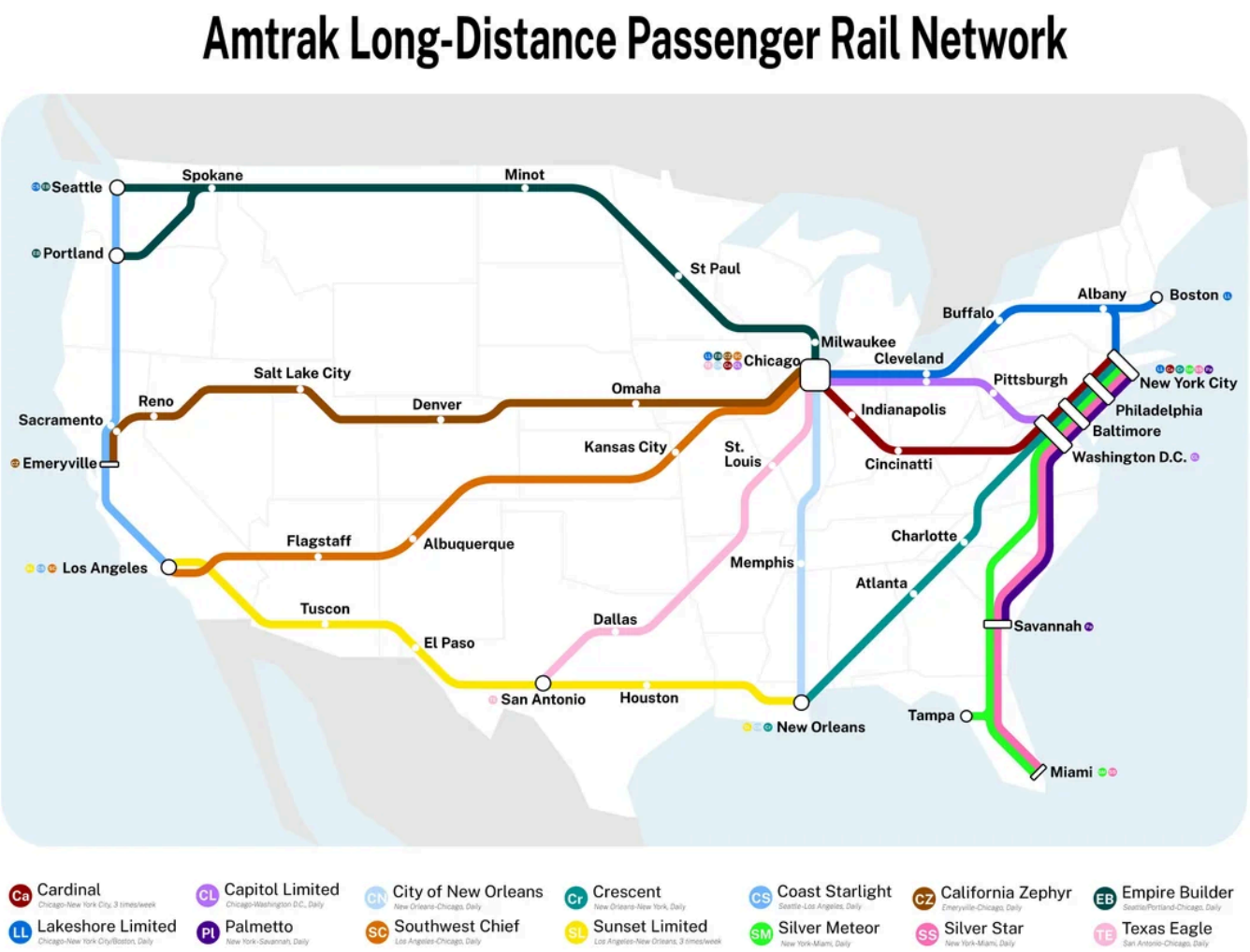


Figure 1: Amtrak Route Map [1]

## Itinerary

Currently, the itinerary of cities is

- Marshall, Texas -> Chicago (Texas Eagle) April 25-26
- Chicago -> Boston (Lakeshore Limited) April 26-27
- Boston -> New York City (Lakeshore Limited) April 30
- New York City -> Philadelphia (Vermonter) May 5
- Philadelpha -> Washington D.C. (Northeast Regional) May 8
- Washington D.C. -> Chicago (Floridian) May 11th-May 12
- Chicago -> Seattle (Empire Builder) May 12-May 14
- Seattle -> Emeryville (Coast Starlight) May 17-May 18
- Emeryville -> Chicago (California Zephyr) May 20-22
- Chicago -> Dallas (Texas Eagle) May 23-May 24

## Boston - April 27th-30th

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Day 1 – Apr 28** | 9:00 AM | Boston Common | FREE | Start here |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Morning | Public Garden | FREE | Swan Boats seasonal |
| | Morning | Beacon Hill Friends House | FREE | Brief stop |
| | Mid-Morning | Freedom Trail (2.5 mi) | FREE | Follow red brick path |
| | Mid-Morning | Park Street Church | FREE | Along trail |
| | Mid-Morning | Granary Burying Ground | FREE | Along trail |
| | Mid-Morning | King’s Chapel | FREE | Along trail |
| | Lunch | Faneuil Hall & Quincy Market | FREE | Browse & eat |
| | Afternoon | Paul Revere House | $5.50 | |
| | Afternoon | Old North Church | $5 | |
| | Evening | Rose Kennedy Greenway | FREE | Neighborhood stroll |
| | Evening | Beacon Hill | FREE | End near South Station |
| **Day 2 — Apr 29** | Morning | Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum | $15 | 2–3 hours (Fenway) |
| | Afternoon | Harvard Art Museums | FREE | Student ID; take T from Fenway |
| | Afternoon | Harvard Square + Harvard Yard | FREE | Walk around after museums |
| **Day 3 — Apr 30** | Morning | Newbury Street | FREE | Shopping/dining |
| | Morning | Trinity Church | FREE | Back Bay, 30 min |
| | Morning | Boston Public Library | FREE | Back Bay, 30 min |
| | Afternoon | Seaport District | FREE | Restaurants & browsing |
| | **7:47 PM** | **Depart South Station** | — | Seaport is a short walk to South Station |

## New York City - April 30th-May 5th

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Apr 30** | Evening | Arrive Queens | — | Check in, rest |
| **Day 1 — May 1 (Manhattan)** | Morning | Times Square | FREE | Less crowded early |
| | Morning | New York Public Library | FREE | |
| | Mid-Morning | Grand Central Station | FREE | |
| | Mid-Morning | Rockefeller Center | FREE | Exterior |
| | Afternoon | AMNH | Pay-what-you-wish | Can pay $1 w/ student ID |
| | Afternoon | Central Park | FREE | Walk through after AMNH |
| | Evening | Greenwich Village | FREE | Dinner & wander |
| **Day 2 — May 2 (Manhattan)** | Morning | 5th Avenue + St. Patrick’s Cathedral | FREE | Start midtown, walk north |
| | Mid-Morning | Museum Mile (82nd–105th St) | — | All on 5th Ave |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Mid-Morning | The Met | Pay-what-you-wish | Can pay $1 w/ student ID |
| | Mid-Morning | El Museo del Barrio | **FREE** | Students free |
| | Mid-Morning | Museum of the City of New York | **FREE** | Students free |
| | Afternoon | Guggenheim | **$18** | Student ID |
| | Evening ⭐ | MoMA | **FREE** | Free every Fri 5:30–9pm |
| **Day 3 — May 3 (Queens)** | Morning | Flushing Chinatown | FREE | Best cheap food in NYC |
| | Afternoon | Flushing Meadows-Corona Park | FREE | USTA, Queens Museum nearby |
| | Evening | Jackson Heights | FREE | Little India — great cheap eats |
| **Day 4 — May 4 (Brooklyn)** | Morning | Brooklyn Botanic Garden | ~$15 | Free Tues & select Sat mornings |
| | Midday | Prospect Park | FREE | Adjacent to BBG |
| | Afternoon | DUMBO | FREE | Great Manhattan Bridge views |
| | Afternoon | Walk Brooklyn Bridge | FREE | Brooklyn→Manhattan side |
| | Evening | Little Italy | FREE | Dinner on the way back |
| **Day 5 — May 5 (Queens AM)** | Morning | Explore local Queens neighborhood | FREE | Easy since you're staying there |
| | Mid-Morning | Statue of Liberty — Battery Park or Staten Island Ferry | FREE | Ferry is free + closer views |
| | **6:49 PM** | **Depart NYC** | — | |

## Philadelphia - May 5th-May 8th

Figure 2: Map of Philadelphia's Murals

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **May 5** | 8:07 PM | Arrive Philadelphia | — | Grab food near hotel; Reading Terminal closes ~6pm |
| **Day 1 — May 6 (Old City)** | Morning | Liberty Bell | **FREE** | NPS; no tickets needed |
| | Morning | Independence Hall | **FREE** | Free timed-entry — book at recreation.gov in advance |
| | Mid-Morning | Free Quaker Meeting House | **FREE** | Steps from Independence Hall |
| | Mid-Morning | Arch Street Meeting House | Free/donation | Oldest continuously used meetinghouse in the US |
| | Mid-Morning | Elfreth’s Alley | **FREE** | Oldest residential street in the US; very photogenic |
| | Midday | Reading Terminal Market | FREE to enter | Lunch; $8–15 for a full meal |
| | Afternoon | Delaware River Waterfront | **FREE** | Penn’s Landing, scenic walk |
| | Evening | Old City murals / wander | **FREE** | Philly has some of the best street art in the US |
| **Day 2 — May 7 (South Philly + Center City)** | Morning | Italian Market | **FREE** | Oldest open-air market in the US; great cheap eats |
| | Mid-Morning | Magic Gardens | **~$10** | Student discount; Isaiah Zagar mosaic art on South Street |
| | Midday | South Street | **FREE** | Wander, lunch, shops |
| | Afternoon | Rittenhouse Square | **FREE** | Beautiful park, upscale neighborhood |
| | Afternoon | City Hall | **FREE** | Walk around; observation tower ~$8 |
| | Evening | Fishtown | **FREE** | Hip neighborhood, great cheap dinner spots |
| **Day 3 — May 8 (Parkway Morning)** | Morning | Benjamin Franklin Parkway | **FREE** | Outdoor scenic boulevard |
| | Mid-Morning | Philadelphia Museum of Art | **~$14** | Student ID; Rocky steps are always free |
| | **1:47 PM** | **Depart Philadelphia** | — | |

## Washington D.C. - May 8th-May 11th

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Day 1 — May 8 (Thu)** | 3:45 PM | Arrive DC | — | Check in, freshen up |
| | 5:30 PM | Embassy Row | FREE | Stroll Massachusetts Ave NW |
| | Evening | Dupont Circle | FREE | Dinner, neighborhood walk |
| **Day 2 — May 9 (Fri)** | 8:00 AM | Arlington National Cemetery | FREE | Tomb of Unknown Soldier, 2–3 hrs |
| | ↳ | Arlington House | FREE | Along the way |
| | Midday | Cross Memorial Bridge | — | Walk or rideshare to the Mall |
| | Afternoon | Smithsonian Museums | FREE | Pick 2–3: Air & Space, Natural History, American History |
| | Late Afternoon | Library of Congress | FREE | Thomas Jefferson Building tour |
| | Evening | Navy Yard / The Yards | FREE | Waterfront bars & dinner |
| **Day 3 — May 10 (Sat)** | Morning | Rockville | FREE | Pike & Rose area, downtown Rockville |
| | ↳ | Metro back | — | Red Line |
| | Afternoon | Baltimore (with Narein) | Varies | MARC train from Union Station (~45 min, $9) |
| | ↳ | Inner Harbor / Fell’s Point | FREE | Explore with Narein |
| | Evening | Return to DC | — | MARC back to Union Station |
| **Day 4 — May 11 (Sun)** | 9:00 AM | Mount Vernon | $28 | Drive/rideshare ~30 min south |
| | 11:30 AM | Old Town Alexandria | FREE | King Street, waterfront stroll |
| | ↳ | Lunch | Varies | King Street restaurant row |
| | 2:00 PM | Head back to DC | — | Metro (King St–Old Town Blue/Yellow) |
| | **4:00 PM** | **Depart DC** | — | |

## Seattle - May 14-May 17

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **May 14 — Arrive 11:30am** | Afternoon | Pike Place Market + Original Starbucks | FREE to enter | 1912 Pike Place; expect a line |
| | Afternoon | Seattle Waterfront / Pier 57 | FREE | Walk along the water |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Afternoon | Pioneer Square | FREE | Oldest neighborhood in Seattle |
| | Evening | Capitol Hill | FREE | Best food/ nightlife neighborhood |
| **Day 2 — May 15** | Morning | Kerry Park | FREE | Best Space Needle + skyline view |
| | Morning | Seattle Center grounds | FREE | Space Needle exterior, fountain |
| | Mid-Morning | Chihuly Garden and Glass | ~$27 | Student ID |
| | Midday | International District | FREE | Cheap lunch |
| | Afternoon | Fremont + Fremont Troll | FREE | Canal views |
| | Afternoon | Gas Works Park | FREE | Great lake views |
| **Day 3 — May 16** | Morning | Seattle Art Museum | ~$15 | Student ID |
| | Mid-Morning | Seattle Public Library | FREE | Architecturally stunning inside |
| | Midday | Ballard neighborhood | FREE | Fishermen’s Terminal, Ballard Locks (free) |
| | Afternoon | University of Washington campus | FREE | Beautiful quad, free to walk |
| | Evening | Last dinner in Capitol Hill | — | |
| **May 17** | By 9:55 AM | Depart Seattle | — | |

## San Francisco - May 18-May 20

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **May 18 — Arrive 8:30am** | Morning | Ferry Building | FREE | Great breakfast, farmers market on Sat |
| | Morning | Embarcadero / Waterfront walk | FREE | |
| | Mid-Morning | Chinatown | FREE | Walk through, cheap eats |
| | Midday | North Beach | FREE | City Lights Bookstore, Beat Generation neighborhood |
| | Afternoon | Coit Tower | FREE exterior | Views nearly as good from outside |
| | Afternoon | Fisherman’s Wharf | FREE to wander | |
| | Evening | Mission District | FREE | Best cheap food in SF; Dolores Park stroll |
| **Day 2 — May 19** | Morning | Golden Gate Bridge | FREE | Walk across |
| | Mid-Morning | Golden Gate Park | FREE | |

| Day | Time | Stop | Cost | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | ↳ | de Young Museum | ~$15 | Student ID; free first Tues of month |
| | Midday | Haight-Ashbury | FREE | Historic counterculture neighborhood |
| | Afternoon | SFMOMA | ~$19 | Free last Thursday evening |
| | Evening | Castro District | FREE | Iconic neighborhood, great food |
| **May 20** | By 8:30 AM | Depart SF | — | Pack the night before |

Add Lombard Street + Mission Style Burrito and Ghiradelli

## Pizza List

The most iconic pizzas from each city are:

| City | Style | Where | Est. Cost |
|---|---|---|---|
| Boston | Thin crust New England | Regina Pizzeria (North End) | ~$4/slice |
| NYC | Classic NY dollar slice | Any corner shop | ~$2–3/slice |
| Philadelphia | Tomato pie (no cheese) | Santucci's or Lorenzo's | ~$8–12 |
| DC | Jumbo slice | Any Adams Morgan spot | ~$4–5 |
| Seattle | No iconic style | Ballard Pizza Co. or similar | ~$4/slice |
| SF | Sourdough crust | Tony's Pizza Napoletana | ~$5/slice |

## Packing List

### Essentials

- ☑ Hiking Bag
- ☑ Water Bottle
- ☑ Sleeping Bag
- ☑ Drawstring Bag
- ☐ Trackers

### Clothing

### Essentials

- ☑ 3 Pants
- ☑ 3 Undershirt
- ☑ 3 Athletic T-Shirts
- ☑ 4 Socks
- ☑ 4 Underwear
- ☑ Windbreaker
- ☐ Shoes

### Extra

- ☑ Emergency Poncho
- ☑ Umbrella
- ☑ Needle/Thread

### Toiletries

- ☑ Towel
- ☑ Toothbrush/toothpaste
- ☑ Tongue Cleaner
- ☑ Mouth Guard
- ☑ Deodorant
- ☑ Comb
- ☑ Beard Trimmer
- ☑ First Aid Kit
- ☑ Sunscreen
- ☑ First Aid Kit
- ☐ Hand sanitizer
- ☐ Wet Wipes

### Electronics

- ☐ Phone/Charger
- ☐ Laptop/Charger

### Food

### Grocery Items

- ☑ Bread
- ☑ Hard Cheese
- ☑ Granola Bars
- ☑ Dried Fruit

### Other

- ☑ Playing Cards
- ☑ Driver's License
- ☑ Pictures of Passport
- ☑ Credit/Debit Card
- ☑ Tickets

**Day 1 - April 25 (Sat)**

**Day 2 - April 26 (Sun)**

**Day 3 - April 27 (Mon)**

**Day 4 - April 28 (Tue)**

**Day 5 - April 29 (Wed)**

**Day 6 - April 30 (Thu)**

**Day 7 - May 1 (Fri)**

**Day 8 - May 2 (Sat)**

**Day 9 - May 3 (Sun)**

**Day 10 - May 4 (Mon)**

**Day 11 - May 5 (Tue)**

**Day 12 - May 6 (Wed)**

**Day 13 - May 7 (Thu)**

**Day 14 - May 8 (Fri)**

**Day 15 - May 9 (Sat)**

**Day 16 - May 10 (Sun)**

**Day 17 - May 11 (Mon)**

**Day 18 - May 12 (Tue)**

**Day 19 - May 13 (Wed)**

**Day 20 - May 14 (Thu)**

**Day 21 - May 15 (Fri)**

**Day 22 - May 16 (Sat)**

**Day 23 - May 17 (Sun)**

**Day 24 - May 18 (Mon)**

**Day 25 - May 19 (Tue)**

**Day 26 - May 20 (Wed)**

**Day 27 - May 21 (Thu)**

**Day 28 - May 22 (Fri)**

**Day 29 - May 23 (Sat)**

**Day 30 - May 24 (Sun)**

# Bibliography

[1] caliberal, "A map I made showing the Amtrak long-distance routes." 2023.